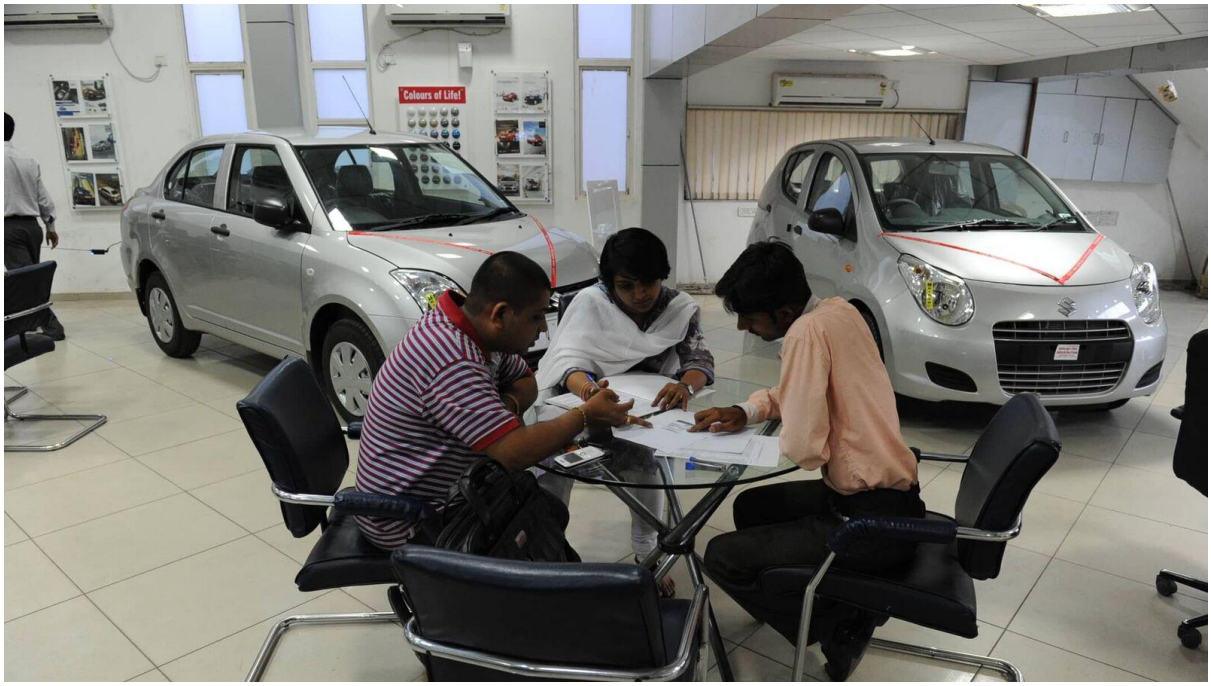
Project Pragna at Surya Motors Limited

Company Background



Surya Motors Limited is one of India's fastest-growing mid-sized automobile manufacturers, headquartered in Pune, Maharashtra. Established in 1998 as a family-owned enterprise producing compact commercial vehicles, the company had evolved into a diversified automotive player manufacturing passenger cars, small commercial vehicles, and hybrid utility vehicles. By 2025, Surya Motors operated three major plants—in Pune, Sriperumbudur in Tamil Nadu, and Sanand in Gujarat—serving both domestic and export markets across South Asia and parts of Africa. The company employed nearly 11,000 workers and recorded revenues of ₹18,000 crore in the previous financial year. Its brand positioning centered around fuel efficiency, durability, and cost-effective ownership, appealing to India's aspirational middle class and small business owners.

The executive leadership team reflected India's regional diversity and professional mobility. The CEO, Arvind Rao from Karnataka, was an alumnus of IISc and IIM Bangalore and had joined Surya Motors after two decades in multinational automotive firms. The CFO, Gurpreet Singh from Punjab, had previously worked in Singapore before returning to India. The CHRO, Meenakshi Iyer from Chennai, had built her career in HR transformation across large manufacturing enterprises. The CMO, Rituparna Chatterjee from Kolkata, had experience in digital-first consumer brands. The VP (Production), Jayesh Patel from Gujarat, was a mechanical engineer who had spent 25 years in plant operations. The Chief Procurement Manager, Nandakumar Nair from Kerala, was known for his meticulous documentation and vendor negotiation skills. The Head of Logistics, Imran Khan from Uttar Pradesh, had risen through the ranks from warehouse supervisor to executive leadership. The Head of Legal, Kavita Deshpande from Mumbai, had extensive courtroom experience in product liability cases. The Chief Customer Experience Manager, Bhavna Reddy from Telangana, oversaw call centers and service networks across India.

By early 2026, Surya Motors was at an inflection point. Its sales had grown rapidly over the past five years, but operational complexity had grown even faster. The company had recently launched its new hybrid SUV, the Surya Astra, which promised industry-leading mileage and compliance with the latest emission standards. Pre-orders exceeded expectations, but so did

the volume of customer interactions. Each new product introduction amplified the scale of information exchange between customers, dealers, vendors, employees, and regulatory bodies. What once could be managed through manual workflows and siloed departments now seemed increasingly unwieldy.

The Customer Deluge

Bhavna Reddy began every Monday morning reviewing dashboards summarizing weekly call volumes across Surya Motors' five regional contact centers. In the week following the Astra launch, the company had received more than 85,000 inbound customer queries. These ranged from prospective buyers asking about fuel efficiency in real-world conditions, to detailed questions about insurance tie-ups, service intervals, emission compliance under BS-VI norms, warranty clauses, and resale value projections. "Customers are no longer satisfied with brochures," Bhavna remarked during a leadership meeting. "They want conversational clarity, not static PDFs."

The contact center executives were trained extensively, but the scale and specificity of queries often outpaced training cycles. A customer in Jaipur might ask about how Astra's hybrid battery performed in extreme summer temperatures, while another in Shillong might inquire about hill-start torque and service network coverage in the Northeast. Escalations had increased by 23 percent in the last quarter. Customers expected immediate, precise answers and often compared Surya Motors' responsiveness with global automotive brands known for seamless digital engagement. The CMO, Rituparna, noted that online review forums were beginning to reflect impatience. "Response time is becoming part of brand equity," she said.

In parallel, complaints had grown in proportion to sales. Issues ranged from minor defects such as faulty infotainment systems to allegations of delayed deliveries due to logistical bottlenecks. Some customers alleged that dealership staff had miscommunicated service policies. Others were dissatisfied with turnaround time for spare parts. Each complaint triggered an internal workflow: call logging, case categorization, dealer coordination, plant-level inspection if required, and sometimes goodwill compensation. The sheer administrative effort required to manage this process was substantial. Bhavna estimated that nearly 40 percent of her team's time was spent coordinating across departments rather than directly addressing customers.

Conversational Commerce Expectations

Rituparna Chatterjee had been advocating for a more interactive digital interface for over a year. Surya Motors' website allowed customers to filter vehicles by price range, engine type, and fuel efficiency, but younger consumers increasingly expected dynamic conversations. During a marketing review, Rituparna presented data indicating that 62 percent of visitors abandoned the website without completing inquiry forms. "They want to ask, 'Which car suits my daily commute of 40 kilometers with occasional highway travel?'" she explained. "They want a dialogue, not dropdown menus."

Dealers had also expressed frustration. Prospective customers often arrived at showrooms armed with partial information from social media discussions and online forums. Sales executives then spent considerable time clarifying misconceptions. The marketing team maintained active social media accounts across Instagram, YouTube, LinkedIn, and regional

platforms. However, coordinating posts, ensuring consistency of messaging in multiple languages, and adhering to scheduled campaigns required manual oversight. Missed posting times or inconsistent responses to comments occasionally resulted in negative engagement spikes. The digital marketing team of 12 found itself stretched thin, especially during product launches.

Internal Employee Queries

While customer-facing functions were under pressure, internal operations were not immune. Meenakshi Iyer, the CHRO, observed a sharp increase in employee queries over the past two years. Surya Motors had expanded its workforce significantly, including hiring engineers, IT professionals, and plant operators. Employees frequently sought clarification on leave policies, travel reimbursements, shift allowances, performance appraisal timelines, and medical insurance coverage. The HR helpdesk received approximately 1,200 tickets daily across email and internal portals.

“Most of these questions are repetitive,” Meenakshi told the executive team. “But each still requires human review.” HR executives manually responded to emails or forwarded them to relevant sub-departments. Response time averaged two working days, which some employees considered slow, especially when travel approvals or leave applications were time-sensitive. The administrative load was compounded by the need to plan travel for engineers and sales managers who frequently visited dealers, suppliers, or plants. Travel planning involved checking budgets, comparing flight options, booking hotels, and ensuring policy compliance. Administrative assistants spent hours coordinating itineraries, often through multiple email threads.

Procurement Complexity

Nandakumar Nair’s procurement department managed capital expenditures ranging from robotic welding machines to assembly line automation equipment. Each capital purchase began with drafting a detailed Request for Proposal (RFP), which was then circulated to pre-qualified vendors. Proposals arrived in varying formats—some as structured documents, others as lengthy PDFs with annexures. Procurement executives created comparison matrices in spreadsheets, manually extracting technical specifications, pricing details, delivery timelines, and warranty clauses.

The evaluation process often took weeks. “Every proposal is like a thesis,” Nandakumar remarked. “And we have to compare them line by line.” Delays in procurement had downstream implications for production schedules. Once a vendor was selected, purchase orders had to be drafted, reviewed, and approved. Any oversight in technical terms could lead to disputes later. Nandakumar was acutely aware that inefficiencies in procurement were not merely administrative; they affected capital utilization and plant uptime.

Legal and Contractual Pressures

Kavita Deshpande faced a growing docket of legal cases, primarily related to alleged product defects and service disputes. In some cases, customers claimed that warranty clauses were

ambiguous. Preparing for court required analyzing lengthy customer agreements, cross-referencing terms and conditions, and drafting responses aligned with both consumer protection laws and internal policy documents. Each case required hours of document review.

“The agreements run into dozens of pages,” Kavita told CEO Arvind Rao during a quarterly risk review. “We have to ensure every clause is interpreted correctly.” Even minor misinterpretations could weaken Surya Motors’ legal standing. The legal team of six often worked late nights, especially when multiple cases were scheduled simultaneously. The need to balance defensive litigation with brand reputation added further complexity.

Finance Bottlenecks

CFO Gurpreet Singh managed a finance department responsible for vendor payments, payroll, tax compliance, and financial reporting. With over 2,000 active vendors, monthly payment cycles were intricate. Invoices arrived through email, courier, and digital portals. While Surya Motors used SAP for financial transactions, reminders for pending payments were often manual. Occasionally, vendors complained about delayed payments, affecting relationships and sometimes supply continuity.

“Cash flow management is critical,” Gurpreet emphasized during a board meeting. “But so is vendor trust.” The finance team maintained spreadsheets to track due dates, but human oversight sometimes led to missed deadlines. Sending reminder emails required manual drafting and coordination. Each delay risked reputational damage in a competitive supplier ecosystem.

Overwhelmed Inboxes

Senior managers, including Arvind Rao, received hundreds of emails daily. These ranged from operational updates to vendor communications, customer escalations, regulatory notices, and internal memos. Arvind often relied on his executive assistant to prioritize emails. However, even assistants struggled to keep pace. Important action items were occasionally buried under routine correspondence.

“I spend the first two hours of every morning just scanning emails,” Arvind confided to Gurpreet. “It’s not strategic time.” Several executives echoed similar concerns. They wished for concise summaries highlighting critical tasks and deadlines. The administrative overhead of information management was consuming valuable leadership bandwidth.

Shop Floor Observations

At the Sanand plant in Gujarat, VP (Production) Jayesh Patel conducted regular walk-throughs of the assembly line. Workers frequently noticed minor irregularities—slight vibrations in welding arms, intermittent sensor glitches, or unusual noise in conveyor belts. Reporting these issues required informing supervisors, who might not always be immediately available. Some minor problems escalated into larger maintenance incidents when not addressed promptly.

“Small cracks become big fractures,” Jayesh often reminded his team. Yet the communication chain between workers and supervisors remained hierarchical. Workers desired a mechanism

to log observations and receive immediate guidance. The culture emphasized safety and quality, but real-time responsiveness was inconsistent.

SAP Coordination Challenges

Surya Motors relied on SAP for managing production orders, material availability, and capacity planning. Before initiating any new product batch, production planners had to manually verify material stock levels and machine capacity within SAP. This process was repetitive and required careful navigation across multiple modules. Any oversight could delay production or cause stockouts.

Imran Khan, overseeing logistics, often faced last-minute adjustments due to mismatches between planned and available inventory. “The system has the data,” he noted during an operations review. “But connecting the dots takes time.” Each new product variant increased the complexity of coordination between procurement, production, and logistics.

Social Media Coordination

Surya Motors maintained a strong presence across multiple digital platforms. Rituparna’s team scheduled promotional posts, service reminders, and customer engagement content. However, managing multiple platforms required manual scheduling and cross-checking. A missed post or inconsistent response could lead to negative publicity.

During the Astra launch week, a delay in responding to a viral customer complaint resulted in a spike in negative comments. “We cannot afford reactive communication,” Rituparna said during a crisis debrief. The team needed consistent, timely engagement across channels, but manual oversight made this challenging.

The Leadership Conclave

In March 2026, Arvind Rao convened a two-day leadership retreat in Lonavala. The agenda was titled “Project Pragna,” a Sanskrit word implying wisdom and foresight. Each executive was asked to present their top three operational pain points and the consequences of inaction.

Bhavna spoke first, emphasizing customer query overload and complaint management inefficiencies. Meenakshi highlighted HR helpdesk bottlenecks and travel coordination burdens. Nandakumar detailed procurement delays and evaluation complexities. Kavita described the mounting pressure of legal document analysis. Gurpreet underscored payment tracking inefficiencies. Rituparna pointed to conversational expectations of customers and social media coordination gaps. Jayesh and Imran elaborated on shop floor communication and SAP verification challenges.

As discussions progressed, a common theme emerged: fragmentation. Information existed within systems—call logs, SAP modules, HR portals, email servers—but these systems operated in silos. Manual interventions bridged gaps, but at significant time cost. “We have islands of efficiency,” Arvind summarized. “But no unified flow.”

The retreat concluded with a sense of urgency. Surya Motors was not facing a single crisis but a constellation of inefficiencies that collectively threatened agility. Competitors were becoming more digitally integrated. Customers were less tolerant of delays. Employees expected faster internal responses. Vendors demanded timely payments. Regulators required compliance precision.

Arvind closed the session with a reflective remark: “We built Surya Motors on engineering excellence. Now we must match that with operational intelligence.” The leadership team returned to Pune with the mandate to examine how technology, processes, and organizational design could evolve to address the interconnected challenges.

Epilogue: The Crossroads

By April 2026, cross-functional working groups had been formed under the banner of Project Pragna. Each department was tasked with mapping workflows, identifying repetitive patterns, and documenting escalation paths. Early findings suggested that up to 35 percent of managerial time across departments was spent on repetitive coordination tasks rather than strategic decision-making.

Surya Motors stood at a crossroads. Its growth trajectory was strong, its brand respected, and its leadership experienced. Yet the accumulation of operational friction posed long-term risks. Whether the company could redesign its workflows to meet rising expectations—without losing its cultural cohesion—remained an open question.

As Arvind Rao looked out from his office window overlooking the Pune plant, he reflected on the journey from a small manufacturing unit to a national brand. “Scale changes the game,” he murmured to himself. “The question is whether we are ready to change with it.”